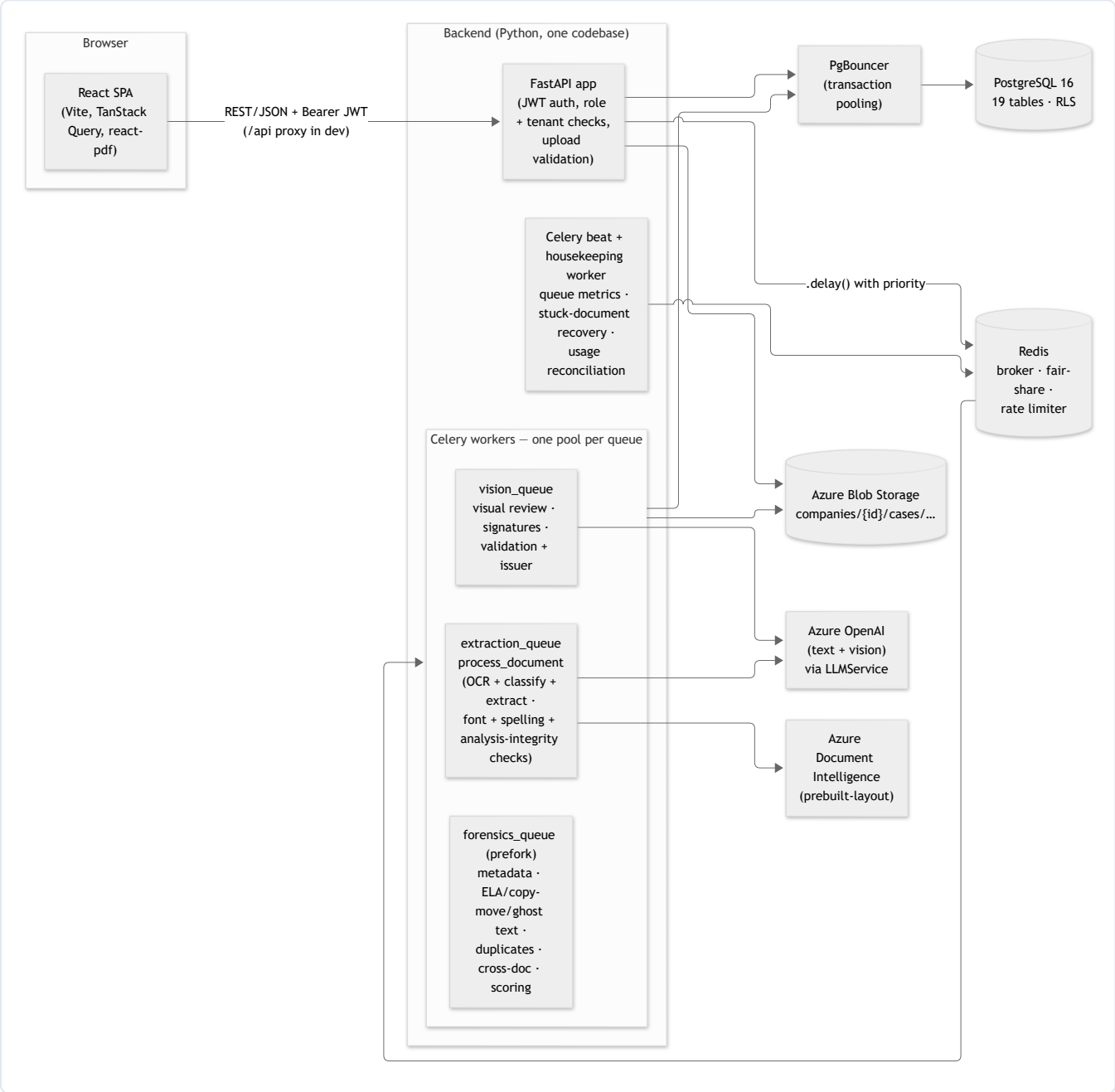
Architecture overview

FDDT (Fraud Document Detection Tool) authenticates third-party documents — vendor invoices, school documents, quotations, travel claims and the payment evidence that supports them — *before* a payment or approval is made. A user submits a **case** containing one or more PDF documents. The system extracts their data, runs a battery of automated checks, turns the results into an explainable risk score, and hands the case to a human reviewer (L1, escalating to L2 when needed) who approves, rejects or escalates it. Every step is written to an append-only audit log.

Several client **companies** share one deployment; each company's users see only that company's data, enforced twice — in the application and by PostgreSQL Row-Level Security (multi-tenancy.md).

System diagram



Everything intelligent is a managed cloud API or a classical library. **No model is trained or hosted** (a design rule of the platform).

Tech stack

Layer	Technology	Used for
API	FastAPI 0.121, Pydantic 2, Uvicorn	REST endpoints, validation, OpenAPI
Auth	PyJWT (HS256), bcrypt	Email/password login; 15-minute bearer tokens carrying `role`, `company_id`, `is_platform_admin`, `ver`; rotating httpOnly refresh-token cookie (authentication.md)
Database	PostgreSQL 16, SQLAlchemy 2, Alembic, psycopg2	Persistence, migrations (25), Row-Level Security per company
Connection pooling	PgBouncer (transaction mode)	Multiplexes API + worker connections onto ≤ 60 server connections
Queue	Celery 5.4 + Redis 7	Three queues (extraction / vision / forensics), fair-share priorities, beat jobs
Rate limiting	Redis sliding windows (`services/rate_limiter.py` , `services/login_throttle.py`)	Global caps on Azure calls across every worker; sign-in throttling per email address and per IP
File store	Azure Blob Storage (`azure-storage-blob`)	Immutable originals, signature crops, report PDFs (company-prefixed paths)
OCR	Azure Document Intelligence `prebuilt-layout`	Text, tables, key-values and word geometry
LLM	Azure OpenAI (chat completions, strict JSON-schema output)	Classification, field extraction, issuer semantic match, spelling judgment, visual review, signature detect/compare. Every prompt treats the document as untrusted data, never instructions (02a)
PDF forensics	pikepdf, PyMuPDF	Upload validation, metadata, xref/incremental-update analysis, page rendering, report PDF
Image forensics	OpenCV (headless), Pillow, NumPy	ELA, copy-move (BRISK), ghost text (traces of erased text in converted scans), signature crop/pixel comparison
Duplicates	imagehash (pHash)	Near-duplicate page detection (within a company)
Spelling	pyspellchecker (bundled word-frequency lists)	Dictionary pass of the English spelling check, before the LLM judgment
Fuzzy match	rapidfuzz	Issuer registry lookup, signer-name comparison
Workflow	`transitions`	Case state machine
Frontend	React 19, TypeScript 6, Vite 8, React Router 7	SPA, route-level code splitting
UI kit	Tailwind CSS 4, Radix primitives, shadcn-style `ui/` components, lucide-react	Styling and base components
Data	TanStack Query 5	Server state, polling
Forms	React Hook Form + Zod	Form state and validation

Layer	Technology	Used for
PDF view	react-pdf (pdf.js)	Live viewer with overlays, signature-region drawing

Key architectural decisions

1. Modular monolith

One FastAPI app and the Celery workers share one codebase (`backend/app/`), one database and one settings object. Modules are separated by responsibility — `api/` (HTTP), `services/` (logic, mostly pure functions), `tasks/` (Celery wrappers that own DB sessions and audit events), `models/` , `schemas/` , `db/` (sessions and tenancy) — not by deployable unit. The same image runs as API, as each worker pool and as beat, differing only in the start command. The convention that makes this work: **services contain the algorithm and are testable without a database or network; tasks wrap them with I/O.** For example `services/forensics/ela.py` `run_ela_check(pages)` is pure; `tasks/tampering_checks_task.py` downloads the file, renders it, calls the pure function and stores the result.

2. Azure OpenAI behind an `LLMService` abstraction

Classification, field extraction, issuer semantic matching, visual review and signature analysis all use Azure OpenAI. `services/llm_service.py` defines the `LLMService` interface and one implementation, `AzureOpenAILLMService` . Callers depend only on the interface, so switching to another LLM provider means adding one implementation class, not rewriting call sites. The same pattern guards `StorageService` (Azure Blob) and `OCRService` (Document Intelligence). All LLM calls request **strict JSON-schema output** (`response_format: json_schema` , `strict: true`), so every response is validated by a Pydantic model (`DocumentAnalysis` , `PageVisualAnalysis` , `SignatureComparisonResult` , …). Vision calls require a vision-capable deployment (`gpt-4o` , `gpt-4.1` , `gpt-4.1-mini` , …) and raise `LLMConfigurationError` otherwise.

3. Three queues, fair-share, globally rate-limited

Uploads return immediately. The upload endpoint validates the file, commits the document row and enqueues **one task per document per step** — six of them. Each task goes to the queue of the service it depends on: `extraction_queue` (Document Intelligence), `vision_queue` (Azure OpenAI) or `forensics_queue` (local CPU, prefork). Each queue has its own worker pool, so they scale independently. Dispatch is **fair-share per company**: a task's priority comes from how much work its company already has outstanding, so one company's 100-document batch can't starve another company's single upload. Azure calls pass through a **Redis-backed global rate limiter** (requests and tokens per minute, calibrated against real usage) shared by every worker. Tasks commit before every slow step (no transaction is held across a download, an Azure call or CPU work), and check results are written **idempotently** (one row per document + check), so a redelivered task overwrites rather than duplicates. The browser polls `GET /cases/{id}` (every 5 s while the pipeline is incomplete). Details: processing-queues.md.

3b. Event-driven case workflow

State changes go through `services/workflow_service.py` , which drives a `transitions` state machine and **emits** `WorkflowEvent` s (`case_status_changed` , `case_approved` , `case_rejected` , `case_escalated`) to subscribers instead of calling side effects directly. The only subscriber today writes the audit log. A future external case-management integration would be one more `subscribe()` call plus the already-present nullable `cases.external_ref_id` column — no change to the state machine.

4. Immutable, validated originals

Only PDFs are accepted, and every upload is validated **before** it is stored: within the company's own size limit (per-company, set by a platform admin; 10 MB by default), not empty, a PDF by its header bytes, not corrupted, not password-protected (pipeline/01-upload-intake.md). A valid file is written to Blob Storage exactly once, at

`companies/{company_id}/cases/{case_id}/documents/{document_id}_{sha256}{ext}`, with `overwrite=False`; `StorageService` exposes no update or delete. Its SHA-256 is stored on `documents.file_hash` so integrity can be re-verified later — the PDF report does exactly that and prints the result. Nothing downstream mutates the original: forensics render pages **in memory**; the signature crop and the report are *new* blobs (`…/signatures/…`, `…/reports/…`). The private container means the API never hands out the raw blob URL; it mints short-lived SAS URLs (15 minutes by default, 30 for OCR), and refuses to sign a path under another company's prefix.

5. One normalized bounding-box convention

Every located thing — ELA/copy-move regions, visual-review findings, extracted-field positions, signature/stamp regions, signature references — is stored as `{"page": 1-based int, "x", "y", "width", "height"}` where the four numbers are **fractions (0–1) of the page's width/height, origin top-left**. It is resolution-independent, so the same box works on a 200-DPI server render, a browser canvas, and the report. The frontend draws boxes live over the real PDF (`PdfOverlayViewer`) and never saves an annotated image; only the exported report burns findings into *its own* rendered pages.

6. A transparent rules engine, not a model

Risk scoring is a weighted rules engine (`services/risk_scoring_service.py`). Each rule is a row in the company's `risk_rules` describing *what to match* in already-stored check results; there is no per-rule Python. Rules are **immutable and versioned** — editing inserts `version + 1` — and every scoring run (`case_risk_assessments`) freezes the rendered reason text, the exact rule versions and the thresholds it used, so retuning never changes a historical score. New companies start from the platform rule template (`risk_rule_templates`). See pipeline/11-risk-scoring-engine.md.

7. Template-free extraction

One generic pipeline handles every document type: Azure Layout OCR → a single Azure OpenAI call that both classifies the document and extracts core fields plus arbitrary additional fields as `{name, value}` pairs. No per-type extractors exist, so new document types need no engineering.

8. Two-layer tenant isolation

Every tenant-owned table carries `company_id`. The application binds each request's (and each task's) database session to one company and filters every ORM query automatically; independently, PostgreSQL Row-Level Security refuses any row of another company even to SQL with no filter at all. No database role has BYPASSRLS; the platform path sees all rows through an explicit `platform_all` policy. A cross-company id is a 404. See multi-tenancy.md.

9. Explainability over accuracy claims

Weak signals are labelled as such everywhere in code and UI: ELA is a "signal, not a verdict"; signature/stamp detection is presence-and-placement only; signature comparison uses advisory wording ("visually consistent with reference on file", never "verified"); the visual review's AI question is "experimental". Weights reflect that.

Scope of the current build

What each capability area does today, and what is intentionally outside the current scope.

#	Area	Implementation	Where
1	Classification & extraction	Azure OpenAI via `LLMService`, one combined call per document	`services/llm_service.py`

#	Area	Implementation	Where
2	Signature/stamp detection	Azure OpenAI vision model locates signature and stamp regions (presence/placement only)	`services/signature_detection_service.py`
3	AI-generated-content assessment	One question inside the visual-review vision call; experimental, one signal among several. There is no separate content-detection service	`services/visual_inconsistency_service.py`
4	Metadata forensics	pikepdf + PyMuPDF read the PDF's own object model	`services/forensics/metadata_forensics.py`
5	Accepted file types	**PDF only**, within the company's per-file limit (10 MB by default), validated at upload (type by header bytes, corruption, password). Every forensic check is PDF-based	`services/upload_validation.py`
5a	Bulk upload	One zip (within the company's zip limit, 300 MB by default) with one folder per case. Ingested in the background case by case, each document validated like a single upload and queued as soon as its case exists. Partial success, live per-case summary	`services/bulk_upload_service.py`
5b	Upload limits	Per company (`companies.max_file_size_mb` / `max_zip_size_mb`), changed only by a platform admin, audited old → new, effective on the next upload; one source for every upload path	`services/upload_limits.py`
6	Error Level Analysis	Runs only on pages containing an embedded raster image; born-digital text pages return `not_applicable`	`services/forensics/ela.py`
7	Case workflow	Statuses in use: `submitted` , `pending_manual_review` , `approved` , `rejected` . Every scored case goes to the reviewer queue; nothing auto-approves. Escalation moves the case to the L2 reviewer tier (`assigned_tier`), not a status	`services/workflow_service.py`
8	Low-confidence fields	The per-field `uncertain` flag is stored and displayed to the reviewer; it does not change routing, because every case reaches manual review	`services/llm_service.py`
9	Multi-tenancy	Companies, `company_id` everywhere, application filter + PostgreSQL RLS, platform admin with audited read-only support access	`db/tenancy.py` , `api/tenant_access.py`
10	Billing & usage	Per-company counters (cases, documents, files, storage) with nightly reconciliation; platform-admin dashboard	`services/usage_service.py`
11	Processing queues	Three queues, fair-share per company, global Azure rate limiter, queue monitor, JSON queue metrics + `queue_alert` log line	`tasks/celery_app.py` , `tasks/fairshare.py`
12	Notifications	Not part of the current scope (no notifications table, no email sending)	—
13	SLA tracking	Not part of the current scope (no deadline column, no overdue checks)	—
14	Organisation-wide MIS reporting	Not part of the current scope. The *per-case* forensic report is fully built	`services/case_report_service.py`

#	Area	Implementation	Where
15	Frontend libraries	Tables are hand-built per page; no charting library is used	`frontend/package.json`
16	Signature verification	Detection + reviewer-created references + in-case vision comparison + a classical pixel-identical-reuse check. Cross-case library comparison is not built (the `is_library` flag only stores data)	`services/signature_*`
17	Evidence export	Per-case PDF report with file hashes and annotated renders; no bundle of the original files	`services/case_report_service.py`
18	Arabic values	Extracted Arabic field values render with the default text direction on the case detail page; Arabic issuer names render right-to-left in the Issuer Registry settings page	`frontend/src/pages/`
19	Document labels	`school_document, vendor_invoice, commercial_invoice, procurement_documentation, quotation, travel_invoice, payment_evidence, other`. Note the **case** type is `travel_reimbursement` while the **document** label is `travel_invoice`	`services/classification_service.py`, `models/case.py`
20	Cloud deployment	Not built — local development only. The production plan and costs are in deployment/production-deployment.md	—

Security posture

- **Two mandatory checks on every endpoint:** a role check (`require_company_role` / `require_reader` with a minimum rank — `user` < `reviewer_l1` < `reviewer_l2` — or `require_platform_admin`) and a tenant check (the request's session is bound to the caller's company by `get_tenant_db`). The user is re-read from the database on every request; a token whose company or platform flag no longer matches, or whose company is suspended, is refused. Case actions additionally check the case's tier (`app/api/case_access.py` `can_act_on_case`).
- **Tenant isolation is enforced twice** — application-layer filtering and PostgreSQL Row-Level Security — and a cross-company id is a **404**. Platform admins belong to no company, are read-only on company data, and every one of their accesses writes a platform-only audit row that no company user can see.
- **Submitters are deliberately blinded:** `GET /cases` and `GET /cases/{id}` return a neutral "In review" flag and no risk tier/assessment to a `user`, and the case timeline (`GET /cases/{id}/audit-log`) omits the scoring event and strips result details (results, finding and match counts, score, tier, rules fired) from the automated check events — so a bad actor cannot learn the score. A case owned by someone else is a **404, not 403**. *Note:* the per-document check cards on the case page (e.g. "Issuer verification: Flagged") are still shown to the submitter — see the change report R6 for this open decision.
- **Case-content routes are guarded** (`api/case_access.py`). Document upload and `GET …/documents/{id}/file-url` require that the caller is the case's **owner or a reviewer of its company** — anyone else gets a **404** (`load_visible_case`), and a rejected upload writes nothing to storage. The three `signatures` endpoints follow the same rule: the **uploader sets the reference signature during upload**, so the case owner may use them, as may any reviewer; a stranger gets a 404. Covered by `tests/test_case_authorization.py`. A submitter can still read their own case's signature comparison results (`GET …/signature-matches`), unlike the risk assessment, which is withheld.
- **Uploads are validated before storage** (PDF only, within the company's size limit, not corrupted, not password-protected), so a malformed file never reaches Blob Storage, a worker or an Azure API.
- Sessions: a 15-minute access token kept in memory plus a rotating refresh token in an httpOnly, SameSite=Strict cookie, with reuse detection, sign-out, sign-out everywhere and instant revocation on password or account

changes — see authentication.md. There is no self-service password reset (a platform admin resets). Outside local/test the API refuses to start with a weak `JWT_SECRET_KEY`.